

Monk: Warrior of Breathing

Beast Breathing: the Bloodfang Form

*“You think too much, little storm. The beast does not think. The beast moves, and the beast is already behind you.”
(the lesson Stabby finally understood)*

Some warriors learn to still the storm inside them. The Warrior of Beast Breathing learns to ride it. Where other monks seek calm, this form reaches into the wild, animal heart of the fighter: the part that does not hesitate, does not flinch, and does not stop. Practitioners breathe in time with a racing heartbeat rather than a slow one, and when they ignite their breath, their blade glows blood-red and their body moves with the loping, unstoppable grace of a hunting beast.

It is a form born of survival rather than discipline, favored by those who grew up where the strong eat and the slow are eaten. To master it is not to tame the beast, but to become it on command, and to remember how to set it down again afterward.

Monk Level	Feature
3rd	Beast Breathing
6th	First Form: Devour
11th	Advanced Beast Breathing
17th	Third Form: Apex Predator

Level 3: Beast Breathing

Monk Weapons. A katana (and any sword you take up as your signature blade) counts as a Monk weapon for you. You can use your Martial Arts die with it, make your Bonus Action Unarmed Strikes alongside it, and use this subclass’s features through it.

Beast Sense. Your senses are sharp as a hunting animal’s, even out of combat. You have Advantage on Wisdom (Survival) checks made to track creatures, on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell or hearing, and on Charisma (Intimidation) checks.

Igniting the Breath. When you roll Initiative, you can expend 1 Focus Point to ignite your breath for the rest of the combat. It lasts until the combat ends, you have the Incapacitated condition, or you end it (no action required). While your breath is ignited, your weapon glows blood-red and deals an extra 2 Force damage on every hit.

Beast’s Vigor. While your breath is ignited, your Speed increases by 10 feet and you have Advantage on Dexterity saving throws: the wild reflexes of a cornered animal.

Level 6: First Form: Devour

First Form: Devour. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 1 Focus Point to move up to 15 feet without provoking Opportunity Attacks and make one attack with your Monk weapon. On a hit, the attack deals 3d8 plus your Dexterity modifier Force damage. If this attack reduces the target to 0 Hit Points, you regain the expended Focus Point. This feature replaces Flurry of Blows for you.



Stabby, Bloodfang ignited

Level 11: Advanced Beast Breathing

Advanced Breathing. Your ignited breath grows fiercer. While it is active you gain all its original benefits, and you also have Resistance to Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing damage. In addition, your weapon’s bonus damage increases from 2 to 3.

Sharpened Fang. The damage of your First Form: Devour increases to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier.

Level 17: Third Form: Apex Predator

Third Form: Apex Predator. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 3 Focus Points to become a blur of fang and steel. Move up to your Speed without provoking Opportunity Attacks and make one attack with your Monk weapon against each of up to three different creatures you move within reach of. Each attack deals 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier Force damage on a hit, and each creature hit must succeed on a Strength saving throw or have the Prone condition. For each creature reduced to 0 Hit Points, you regain 1 expended Focus Point.

AT LEVEL 7, STABBY HAS: Beast Breathing (the Level 3 stance) + First Form: Devour (Level 6, 3d8 + Dex). The Level 11 and 17 features unlock as he grows.

Monk: Warrior of Breathing

Water Breathing: the Monastery Form

“Be water. Water does not strike; it flows, and the rock is cut all the same. Now breathe, and begin again.”
(Master Kaelon Windstep)

The Warrior of Water Breathing is the form of the patient master, the discipline that other monks spend their whole lives chasing. Its practitioners learn to move like a river: never rigid, never still, every strike flowing into the next, every blow turned aside by giving way rather than resisting. When they ignite their breath, their blade runs pale blue and cold, and their guard becomes as fluid and unbroken as a current that cannot be grasped.

It is the most traditional of the breathing forms, and the hardest to truly master, for it asks the warrior to be calm in the middle of chaos. Those who walk this path are as often menders as fighters, for the same stillness that turns a blade can also close a wound, and the same patience that wins a duel can sit a long vigil at a friend’s side.

Monk Level	Feature
3rd	Water Breathing
6th	First Form: Flowing Strike
11th	Advanced Water Breathing; Healing Spring
17th	Third Form: Tidal Crash

Level 3: Water Breathing

Monk Weapons. A katana (and any sword you take up as your signature blade) counts as a Monk weapon for you. You can use your Martial Arts die with it, make your Bonus Action Unarmed Strikes alongside it, and use this subclass’s features through it.

Igniting the Breath. When you roll Initiative, you can expend 1 Focus Point to ignite your breath for the rest of the combat. It lasts until the combat ends, you have the Incapacitated condition, or you end it (no action required). While your breath is ignited, your weapon glows pale blue and deals an extra 2 Cold damage on every hit.

Flowing Guard. While your breath is ignited, you gain a +2 bonus to Armor Class against the first attack roll made against you before the start of each of your turns: an ever-moving guard that turns the first blow aside.

Level 6: First Form: Flowing Strike

First Form: Flowing Strike. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 1 Focus Point to shift up to 15 feet without provoking Opportunity Attacks and make one attack with your Monk weapon. On a hit, the attack deals 3d8 plus your Dexterity modifier Cold damage, and the target must succeed on a Dexterity saving throw or have the Prone condition as the current sweeps its feet. This feature replaces Flurry of Blows for you.



Stabby, the Flowing Guard

Level 11: Advanced Water Breathing

Advanced Breathing. Your ignited breath deepens. While it is active you gain all its original benefits, and also: whenever you hit a creature with your Monk weapon, that creature’s Speed is reduced by 10 feet until the start of your next turn as the cold seeps into its limbs.

Sharpened Flow. The damage of your First Form: Flowing Strike increases to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier.

Healing Spring. Once per Long Rest, you can take a Bonus Action to touch a creature (or yourself) and channel the still water’s mending. The target regains 4d8 plus your Wisdom modifier Hit Points.

Level 17: Third Form: Tidal Crash

Third Form: Tidal Crash. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 3 Focus Points to shift up to 20 feet and make one attack with your Monk weapon against each of up to three different creatures within your reach as you flow among them. Each attack deals 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier Cold damage on a hit, and each creature hit must succeed on a Dexterity saving throw or have the Prone condition and its Speed becomes 0 until the end of its next turn, frozen in place by the flood.

AT LEVEL 7, STABBY HAS: Water Breathing (the Level 3 stance) + First Form: Flowing Strike (Level 6, 3d8 + Dex). The Level 11 and 17 features unlock as he grows.

Monk: Warrior of Breathing

Shadow Breathing: the Idol Form

“Do not fear the dark. Breathe it in. Let it fill you, and then there is nothing left in the dark to fear you.”
(a whisper from the idol)

The Warrior of Shadow Breathing is the strangest and most secretive of the forms, a discipline touched by something older than any monastery. Its practitioners breathe in the gloom itself, drawing the dark into their lungs until it answers to them. When they ignite their breath, their blade runs violet-black, the shadows fold around them like a cloak, and they see clearly in darkness that blinds everyone else.

Few teach this form openly, for it walks close to powers most monks are warned away from. Those who carry it often carry a question they cannot yet answer: why the dark heeds them, where the breath truly comes from, and what waits at the end of the path they have started down. Mastered well, it makes a warrior into something the night itself seems to bend around.

Monk Level	Feature
3rd	Shadow Breathing
6th	First Form: Umbral Slash
11th	Advanced Shadow Breathing
17th	Third Form: Eclipse

Level 3: Shadow Breathing

Monk Weapons. A katana (and any sword you take up as your signature blade) counts as a Monk weapon for you. You can use your Martial Arts die with it, make your Bonus Action Unarmed Strikes alongside it, and use this subclass’s features through it.

Eyes of the Idol. The idol’s gift never fully leaves you. You have Darkvision with a range of 60 feet (if you already have Darkvision, its range increases by 60 feet), and you have Advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks; the gloom favors you.

Igniting the Breath. When you roll Initiative, you can expend 1 Focus Point to ignite your breath for the rest of the combat. It lasts until the combat ends, you have the Incapacitated condition, or you end it (no action required). While your breath is ignited, your weapon glows violet-black and deals an extra 2 Necrotic damage on every hit.

One With the Gloom. While your breath is ignited, the dark wraps around you: you have Half Cover (a +2 bonus to AC) against ranged attacks (anywhere, not just in shadow), and you can see normally in magical Darkness.

Level 6: First Form: Umbral Slash

First Form: Umbral Slash. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 1 Focus Point to teleport up to 15 feet to an unoccupied space you can see next to a creature, engulf that creature in a 10-foot Cube of magical Darkness, and make one attack with your Monk weapon against it, with Advantage. On a hit, the attack deals 3d8 plus your Dexterity modifier Necrotic damage. The Darkness lasts until the end of your next turn. This feature replaces Flurry of Blows for you.



Stabby, wreathed in the Idol’s gloom

Level 11: Advanced Shadow Breathing

Advanced Breathing. Your ignited breath drinks deeper of the dark. While it is active you gain all its original benefits, and also: once per turn, when you hit a creature with an attack roll you made with Advantage, the attack deals an extra 2d6 Necrotic damage.

Sharpened Gloom. The damage of your First Form: Umbral Slash increases to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier.

The gloom is his alone. Stabby sees through his own Darkness; his allies can’t. Creatures wrapped in his gloom are hidden from Ursa’s bolts and Lilly’s cannon until the dark lifts, so the party learns to pick different targets while the shadow does its work.

Level 17: Third Form: Eclipse

Third Form: Eclipse. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 3 Focus Points to vanish into the gloom and strike from everywhere at once. Create a 20-foot Cube of magical Darkness centered on yourself (you can see through it), then teleport to and make one attack with your Monk weapon against each of up to three different creatures within it, with Advantage. Each attack deals 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier Necrotic damage on a hit. Each creature hit has the Blinded condition until the end of your next turn, and you remain effectively unseen by everyone but yourself until the Darkness ends.

AT LEVEL 7, STABBY HAS: Shadow Breathing (the Level 3 stance) + First Form: Umbral Slash (Level 6, 3d8 + Dex). The Level 11 and 17 features unlock as he grows.

Magic Items

The Demon-Slayer's Blade

Nichirin Katana

Weapon (Katana), Rare (Requires Attunement by Stabby)



The Nichirin katana and its lacquered saya

This sun-forged demon-slayer blade was made from crimson ore that drinks in dawnlight. While sheathed, the steel looks dark and almost ordinary, but when Stabby ignites his breathing, the blade catches that breath and burns with the color of his chosen form.

Weapon Statistics. The Nichirin katana uses the statistics of a Longsword (1d8 Slashing damage) with the Finesse and Versatile (1d10) properties, and it counts as a Monk weapon for Stabby. Because it has Finesse and is a Monk weapon, Stabby uses his Dexterity for its attack and damage rolls.

Magic Weapon. You gain a +2 bonus to attack and damage rolls made with this magic weapon.

Breath-Kindled Steel. When Stabby ignites his breathing, the blade glows with the color and nature of that form: blood-red for Beast Breathing, pale blue for Water Breathing, or violet-black for Shadow Breathing. This glow is magical but sheds only dim light unless Stabby chooses otherwise.

Setting Down the Kensei's Way

When Stabby takes up a breathing form at Level 7, the Kensei's tricks retire with his old teacher's lessons. He loses **Kensei's Shot** (the bow's bonus-action +1d4) and **Agile Parry** (his +2 AC after blade-and-fist turns), and the Repeating Longbow becomes simply a very good bow, no longer a Monk weapon. In exchange he gains a stance he can ignite **every single fight**, a First Form that turns his bonus action into a **3d8 + 5 strike with 15 feet of free movement**, form gifts that work all day, and a road that grows with him to Level 17. He is trading a parry for a predator's gait, and he gains far more than he gives up. (And Candyfang, outshone by the Nichirin blade, needn't vanish: an heirloom at his belt, or one day, a gift worthy of a Bloodfang.)

Cleansing Edge. Once on each of your turns when you hit a Fiend, Undead, shadow creature, or creature empowered by planar corruption with this katana, the blade burns away corruption until the start of your next turn. While affected, the creature can't regain Hit Points, can't benefit from magical Darkness or shadowy concealment against Stabby, and any visible corruption around the wound briefly burns, cracks, or peels away in sparks of purified light.

Demon-Slayer's Mark. The katana is especially dangerous to creatures twisted by darkness, undeath, or planar corruption. It leaves wounds that glow faintly like banked embers, revealing that the creature has been marked by cleansing sunlight. The blade wounds the corruption, not the creature beneath. When a corrupted guardian falls to it, what breaks is the darkness.

Lore of the Blade

They say the first Nichirin blades were quenched not in water or oil but in the light of dawn itself, folded by smiths who worked only in the hour before sunrise. The ore came from a single mountain that caught the morning sun before anywhere else in the world, and steel drawn from it never forgot that first warmth. A finished blade looks plain and dark in an idle hand; it is waiting. Only a warrior who can kindle their own breath can wake the colour sleeping in the metal.

For a creature of corruption, that waking light is a death sentence. Where an ordinary sword cuts flesh, a Nichirin blade cuts the rot itself: the shadow that hides a fiend, the dark magic that knits an undead back together, the planar taint that lets a horror shrug off honest steel. Stabby's blade chose its colours from his own breathing forms, and now it burns red, blue, or violet to match whichever beast, river, or shadow he calls upon.

A WHISPERED RUMOR. Old hunters claim a Nichirin blade can never be truly stolen: carried by the wrong hand, the steel stays cold and dull and will not take an edge. Whether that is true, or simply a story told to keep thieves honest, no one in living memory has dared find out.